Teaching and rehearsing classroom routines

Use this when a repeated classroom process is unreliable. Routines become useful when students understand, practise and rehearse the exact actions, rather than hear a rule once.

How to do it well

1 Specify the actions. Break the routine into a short sequence with a clear starting cue and ending condition.

2 Explain and model. State why it matters, demonstrate success and show the common mistake students must avoid.

3 Rehearse together. Practise the process with low-demand content, watching the whole class for the precise point of breakdown.

4 Give focused feedback. Name what worked, correct one component and repeat it until the class can perform the sequence fluently.

5 Maintain the habit. Use the same cue, recognise successful execution and re-teach briefly when the routine drifts.

What this sounds like

“We are practising the move from partner talk to listening. At the signal, finish the word you are saying, stop talking and put your pen down.”

Classroom example. A Music teacher teaches how to move from listening to using instruments. Students practise collecting one instrument, waiting with hands still and starting on the cue. When premature playing reappears, the teacher rehearses that part briefly with an easy rhythm. The musical content can then proceed without competing with an uncertain equipment routine.

Top tips that make the technique work

Give the routine a learning purpose. Explain how it protects attention, safety or time, using language students understand.

Teach the cue and response together. Students need to recognise when the routine starts as well as what to do.

Show a convincing non-example. Make the difference visible without turning a pupil’s mistake into public entertainment.

Practise before content matters. Rehearse with an easy task so students can attend to the mechanics.

Revisit after drift. A short reset after holidays or repeated breakdown is usually better than increasingly lengthy reminders.

Do and avoid

Do	Avoid
Give feedback on an observable action.	Assuming older students already know the routine.
Repeat the part that was not secure.	Replacing the cue every time the routine is imperfect.

Further reading

Practitioner guidance; teacher language above is an illustrative BSCS adaptation.

Barton - Embedding habits and routines | DistillED - Behaviour Management